

The Washington Post

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Partly sunny 80/67 • Tomorrow: Showers 72/50 **B20**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, OCTOBER 7, 2025 • \$4

Colo. ban on conversion therapy heads to high court

A Christian therapist seeks the right to counsel gay teens on reconciling attraction, faith

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL

COLORADO SPRINGS — As a licensed therapist and evangelical Christian, Kaley Chiles said she wants to help religious teens who struggle with sexual orientation and gender dysphoria “live a life consistent with their faith” and the identities God has laid out in the Bible. Nonetheless, she turns them away.

Chiles says a state law banning conversion therapy for minors — treatment intended to change the identity or behavior of gay and transgender people — silences her and deprives young people of help many desperately seek to reconcile their faith and feelings.

Not far from Chiles's practice, which sits near the foot of the Rockies, Silas Musick tried to take his life in 2010. The transgender man said the conversion therapy he underwent in Colorado Springs left him distraught. He later testified in support of Colorado's ban and calls conversion therapy bad medicine.

Those clashing perspectives will square off Tuesday at the Supreme Court in one of the highest-profile cases of the new term, one that crosses multiple fault lines in the nation's culture wars: gay and transgender issues, religious liberty, medical practice and First Amendment rights.

The justices will hear arguments in a lawsuit brought by Chiles that says Colorado's restrictions on conversion therapy violate her free speech and that of other Christian therapists who wish to counsel in keeping with their religious tenets. The case could have wide impact — about 30 states have laws similar to Colorado's.

She doesn't want to convert her clients, Chiles said, but does wish to help those who willingly seek to “reduce or eliminate unwanted sexual attractions, change sexual behaviors, or grow in the experience of harmony with one's physical body.”

“This one topic was now being separated from the rest of the law,” she said. SEE COURT ON A6

French prime minister is third to exit in a year

Macron ally resigns less than month into job, as governance woes further grip nation

BY ELLEN FRANCIS

French Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu resigned Monday after less than a month in the job, in a surprise move that deepens the political uncertainty gripping Paris as it confronts serious financial challenges and deadlock over budget policy.

Lecornu, a close ally of French President Emmanuel Macron, became the shortest-serving prime minister in the modern French republic, and the third to fall in a year.

The departure of Macron's latest prime minister highlights France's inability — since Macron called snap elections in 2024 — to form a government that can steady the ship and avert a financial crunch, even as pressure continues to mount.

In a somber speech just hours after appointing his new government, Lecornu said that he “tried to build a path forward” but that the country's polarized political parties were unwilling to compromise. “Being prime minister is a difficult task, undoubtedly more so at this moment,” he said.

SEE FRANCE ON A14

6.9 million

disabled veterans receive benefits on the presumption that their ability to work is impaired.

\$193 billion

Taxpayers are projected to spend a record amount this year — about \$8 billion more than what it costs to run the entire Army — for the Department of Veterans Affairs disability compensation program.

41.7 million

The number of disabilities veterans receive benefits for, a sevenfold increase from 6 million in 2001

LAX CONTROLS OPEN VA TO DUBIOUS DISABILITY CLAIMS



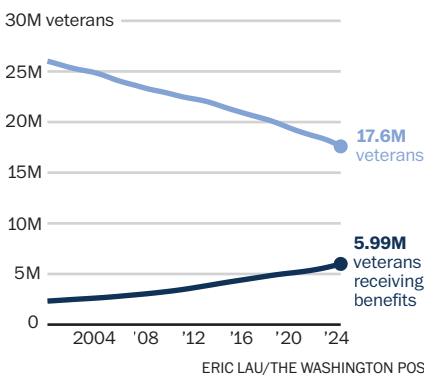
ILLUSTRATION BY DEENA SO'OTEH/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Payouts for mundane conditions — hair loss, eczema and more — that rarely hinder employment cost the U.S. billions per year

BY CRAIG WHITLOCK, LISA REIN AND CAITLIN GILBERT

A growing share of veterans receive disability benefits

While the veteran population decreased by a third from 2001 to 2024, the share of veterans receiving benefits increased from 9 percent to 34 percent.



This article is the first in a series about problems affecting the VA disability system.

ceive disability benefits for eczema, 332,000 for hemorrhoids, 110,000 for benign skin growths, 81,000 for acne and 74,000 for varicose veins, the most recently available figures from VA show. Individual payouts for such mundane conditions vary, but collectively they cost billions of dollars a year.

In contrast, far fewer veterans receive compensation for certain combat-related injuries. About 10,900 service members who have suffered “severe” or “penetrating” brain injuries since 2000 are eligible for benefits. Fewer than 1,700 receive disability payments for losing limbs during the wars in Afghanistan and Iraq.

The Post analyzed 25 years of government data on disability claims and sued VA and the Justice Department under the Freedom of Information Act, forcing

SEE VETERANS ON A8

University funding cuts could kneecap drug development

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON, DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL AND BEN BRASCH

For most people, medicines are a bottle of pills on a shelf — made by drug companies, stocked by pharmacies, prescribed by doctors. But drugs that people take for serious illnesses — to prevent HIV, shrink tumors and treat seizures — have years-long backstories that often trace to basic science experiments in

university laboratories.

That foundation is now under threat. The Trump administration has abruptly frozen billions in research grants to universities it accuses of antisemitism or bias unrelated to the research. Some research is being terminated midstream and further funding cuts loom, jeopardizing the development of new medications that could prove equally lifesaving or life-changing.

Pharmaceutical companies are essen-

tial to developing new drugs, but the early chapters of many medicines' origin stories are based in academia, backed by federal funding. A key reason is the 1980 Bayh-Dole Act, which allows research institutions to patent inventions made with federal funding, creating an incentive to turn basic research into drugs. Numerous studies show how critical taxpayer-funded research has become.

One study found that funding from the

SEE DRUGS ON A20

Orders may leave a mark on the Guard

USE OF TROOPS ENTERS UNCHARTED TERRITORY

Retired officers warn of effects on readiness, training, morale

BY HOLLY BAILEY AND MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

President Donald Trump is taking National Guard deployments into unprecedented territory, seeking to send troops into multiple U.S. cities despite strong opposition from local officials and questions about the purpose and impact of the mission.

Since June, the Trump administration has sent or pledged to send troops to more than half a dozen American cities, all led by Democrats, including Los Angeles, D.C. and Memphis. The administration has argued that military force is needed to address crime in those cities and to back up federal agents charged with enforcing Trump's aggressive push to deport suspected undocumented immigrants.

Over the weekend, the Trump administration escalated its efforts, moving to deploy the National Guard to Chicago and Portland, Oregon, over court challenges and the objections of state and local leaders.

Democratic leaders accuse Trump and his aides of falsely portraying their cities as unruly war zones as an excuse to send the military on partisan missions in ways they believe are also designed to chill political opposition.

“We must now start calling this what it is: Trump's Invasion,” Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker (D) said in a statement. Pritzker said Trump planned to federalize 300 National Guard members from his state, who would be joined by members of the Texas National Guard. “It started with federal agents, it will soon include deploying federalized members of the Illinois National Guard against our wishes, and it will now involve sending in another state's military troops.”

Some Republican governors, including

SEE DEPLOYMENTS ON A11

2 years on, some Israelis who fled Hamas not back

Survivors from 5 communities bordering Gaza face wrenching choices on if, when to return

BY LIOR SOROKA AND HEIDI LEVINE

RUHAMA, ISRAEL — As hundreds of Hamas militants rampaged through her community two years ago, Noa hid in the safe room of her home and opened a map of Israel, scanning it for a place to relocate if her young family came out of the massacre alive.

“Where do we live if we survive this?” she recalled asking her husband, his body pushed against the door of their anti-rocket safe room while she kept their 3-year-old son watching cartoons on her phone, hoping it would drown out the noise of constant gunfire and gunmen shouting.

Two years later, she is still asking.

Many of the tens of thousands of Israelis who were relocated during the days after Oct. 7, 2023, to other parts of the country have returned home. But five of the communities hardest hit by the attack from just over the border in the Gaza Strip are suspended in uncertainty, unsure of when or if they will go back.

Noa, 35, a high school teacher, had lived for seven years with her husband in

SEE ISRAEL ON A13

IN THE NEWS

Pressure on Jay Jones mounts President Donald Trump joined other Republicans in calling for the Democratic candidate for Virginia attorney general to exit the race. **B13**

Coronavirus shots What to know about the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's recommendation regarding the vaccines. **A5**

THE NATION **The Nobel Prize** in medicine was awarded for discoveries about immune system responses. **A2** **Senators** reconvened with no deal to end the shutdown in sight. **A3**

The Supreme Court will not hear Ghislaine Maxwell's appeal. **A6**

THE WORLD **A snowstorm** left hundreds of hikers stranded on Mount Everest, Chinese media reported. **A14**

THE ECONOMY **The maker** of weight-loss drugs Ozempic and Wegovy made the drugs available at Costco for a reduced price. **A16** **Frank Bisignano**, the Social Security commissioner, will also run the IRS, in a move circumventing a Senate confirmation process. **A15**

STYLE **With political clamor** over late-night shows, “South Park” and more, comedy feels important again. **B1**

SPORTS **The Commanders** got mad, got even and got going in the right direction as they rallied to an uplifting win Sunday. **B7**

THE REGION **While visiting** Norfolk, Trump praised the Navy and refrained from weighing in on Virginia's gubernatorial race. **B13** **A man allegedly** possessing explosives was arrested outside a church where Supreme Court justices were expected to attend Mass. **B13**

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